

Call Prep: Emily Brierley, Head of MBA Admissions

Friday 24 July 2026, 11:30 (Buenos Aires time)

Goal of the call

Leave with three concrete things: (1) a firm date for college membership, (2) a parallel backup plan, (3) visa protection, meaning a same-day CAS commitment and help with the priority-visa cost. Tone: calm, firm, solution-focused. Not here to vent or accuse, here to secure commitments.

Opening (about 30 seconds)

"Thank you for making the time. Simply put: I was admitted in round 4 and I am still without college membership after four rejections, while my partner, same profile and same joint application, was placed. Accommodation is not the issue, I arranged that privately. The only thing missing is a membership so my CAS can be issued and I can apply for my visa, and that single piece is holding up my whole process and starting to cost me money, with my flight booked for 25 August."

Key facts (ready to cite)

- Admitted in round 4. College choices submitted 1 June.
- Four rejections: Wolfson, Hughes Hall, St Edmund's (after a reconsideration request), Homerton (capacity, 21 July). Clare Hall was full.
- Homerton turnaround was about a week (sent 15 July, result 21 July).
- My partner was placed at St Edmund's; same nationality and profile, applied jointly.
- I need membership only, not accommodation (arranged privately).
- Membership is described as guaranteed, normally allocated 2 to 3 weeks after accepting the offer.
- The CAS requires all 10 conditions; membership is the only one outside my control (my instalment is paid).
- Visa: flight 25 August. Standard £558 (about 15 working days); Priority £1,058 (+£500); Super Priority £1,558 (+£1,000). A late CAS forces a £500 to £1,000 upgrade, roughly one month's rent, plus the risk of not having the visa in time.

My core arguments

- **Membership is guaranteed.** Being left without one is a process failure against a promise, not me failing a bar.
- **The University sponsors the visa, not the college.** The CAS depends on a confirmed membership, not a specific college. So the ask is to place me somewhere with capacity, not to override any college's judgment.
- **I only need membership, not accommodation,** which widens the pool of colleges that can take me.
- **Fairness, payment versus delivery.** I was required to commit and pay my instalments in full and on time, yet a crucial deliverable that only the school controls (the path to the CAS) is being withheld, and its timing is highly delicate. It should not be possible to be accepted and made to pay first, then be blocked on a component the school owns.
- **Precedent, Oxford.** Oxford, also a collegiate system, reportedly issues the CAS immediately after MBA admission rather than waiting on college placement. This shows a collegiate model can decouple the CAS from a specific college.

What I want to secure

1. A firm date

"What is a realistic date by which I will have membership? Is there an internal deadline to finalise all memberships for the cohort?"

2. Robinson plus backups in parallel

"Since we are already proceeding with Robinson, and I cannot know whether they will accept, can you line up one or two backup colleges that still have availability (for example Lucy Cavendish or Girton), ready to go if Robinson says no? My main concern is avoiding dead time between one rejection and the next."

3. Timing and queue inconsistency (ask as a genuine question)

"I was told in writing that Sidney Sussex closed on 17 July and could not be pursued, yet cohort members were admitted to Sidney and Hughes in the last few days, some round 5. I want to understand the queue. When I asked about Sidney before the 17th, why was my application sent to Homerton instead? And can I still be considered at Sidney or Hughes?"

4. Criteria (neutral, not an accusation)

"My partner and I share nationality, background and profile and applied together, yet she was placed and I was not. To understand it: is college gender balance a factor that is weighed in allocation?"

5. Visa protection (key)

"I accept the CAS needs all 10 conditions. Given membership is the only one outside my control: can you commit to issuing the CAS the same day membership is confirmed? Can the school expedite the CAS or the visa? If the delay forces me onto a priority or super-priority visa, will the school cover or contribute to that extra cost, since the delay is on your side? And given Oxford issues the CAS at admission, is a comparable solution possible here?"

6. Contingency

"If no college is secured by [date], what is the plan? I need to resolve this for this cohort. I turned down three other offers, gave up my income and booked flights, so deferring is not something I can absorb."

If she pushes back

- **"Colleges decide, we can't control it."** → "Understood, but membership is guaranteed and the CAS depends on any membership, not a specific college. I am not asking you to override a college, I am asking the school to ensure I am placed somewhere with capacity before my visa window closes. What is the plan to guarantee that?"
- **"We are already following up."** → "I appreciate it. But one college at a time has cost about a week each. Can we run submissions in parallel with a committed date?"
- **"Sidney closed on 17 July."** → "Then how are cohort members being admitted there and at Hughes in the last few days, some round 5? I genuinely want to understand the queue and whether I can still be considered."
- **"The CAS needs all 10 conditions."** → "Accepted. Given that, will you issue it the same day membership lands, and help mitigate the priority-visa cost this delay is creating?"
- **"You could defer."** → "I cannot. I have irreversible commitments and flights. I need to start this year."

Close

"Thank you. Can we confirm the next steps, who owns each one, and a date? I would appreciate a short email afterwards summarising what we agreed."

Reminders to myself

- Stay calm and warm. Emily can help me, she is not the enemy.
- No nationality allegation. Gender is a question, not a charge.
- Take notes live: names, dates, owners.
- Do not end the call without a date and a backup plan.